

The available content types varies from topic to topic, since as admitted by MIT, “Each MIT OCW course Web site is developed individually with the participating faculty and instructors. MIT faculty and instructors publish only as much content as they are comfortable having on a Web site that is freely accessible worldwide.” (<http://ocw.mit.edu/OcwWeb/Global/OCWHelp/help.htm#18>). So, some faculty members may only offer a reading list and a set of questionnaires; while someone like Professor Levin offers the whole nine yards including the complete video recording of the lectures. Professor Levin’s topics are Newtonian Mechanics, Electricity and Magnetism, and Vibration and Waves for the undergraduate course. Since the recordings are in Real Media Streaming format, you need to be online to view the stream. Alternatively, you can follow the steps mentioned at <http://federermagic.blogspot.com/2005/06/how-to-save-streaming-videos.html> to save the recordings for offline viewing. Expect file sizes to be large!

The bulk of the content offered at the site is at best an accessory to enhance one’s understanding of the subject. A student would still need access to a standard source of information, like a textbook or another online site offering educational content, to really exploit the content offered by MIT. Only the video recordings stand as a wholesome educational avenue. The rest, like lecture notes and slides, are small pieces of a puzzle that would be of no use unless the corresponding course content is also available to the student. Similarly the quizzes and questionnaires are also of no use to a student who does not yet have the relevant knowledge.

In conclusion, MIT’s OCW initiative holds a lot of promise and can prove to be a viable alternative to usual educational channels if it could also incorporate standard educational content presently seen in reference books or offer video recordings of all topics. Nevertheless, this initiative offers an excellent opportunity to students worldwide to gain from the expertise of the best that the teaching world has to offer.